



A YOUNG fisherman in La Cruz de Huanacastle, hometown of seven men reportedly killed in a U.S. airstrike.

Drivers sharing habits may cut bills

State proposal would tie motorists' data to premiums. Consumer advocates aren't sold.

BY LAURENCE DARMIENTO

After experiencing the loss of three friends in auto accidents, Assemblymember Tina S. McKinnor decided she needed to take action.

She immersed herself in the movement to improve driving safety, and now the Hawthorne Democrat is writing controversial legislation that could revolutionize how auto insurance rates are set for many California drivers.

McKinnor's Consumer Driving Data Protection Act would allow insurers to track speed, braking and other driving habits to establish a motorist's safety record, a key component in setting individual premiums — as long as the motorist agrees to it.

Although such tracking has Big Brother overtones, the bill promises lower rates for drivers who might not have the best driving record but can show they are now going easy on the gas and have stopped weaving in and out of traffic.

Currently, a driver's safety record is determined by the Department of Motor Vehicles' point system, which considers a driver's moving violations and accidents.

That system would remain in place for those who don't want insurers tracking them and looking over their shoulder every time they get behind the wheel.

The use of so-called telematics, though common in other states, has raised concerns among privacy and consumer groups due to the data collected by insurers and the technology companies that provide the systems. Critics also doubt that the systems do much to reduce collisions.

"This bill forces Californians to choose between their privacy and affordable auto insurance," said Carmen Balber, executive director of Los Angeles advocacy group Consumer Watchdog.

But insurers and safety advocates say it's a more accurate way to determine how likely motorists are to get into a collision — and a method to encourage better driving.

"For me, this is a way to incentivize to slow people down," McKinnor said. "If 10 people opt in and slow down, and if we could save 10 lives, [See Insurance, A12]

Mexican fishermen also target of U.S. boat strikes

BY KATE LINTHICUM

LA CRUZ DE HUANACASTLE, Mexico — Before dawn one morning in mid-February, two boats carrying eight fishermen set out from Mexico's Pacific coast.

They never returned.

The drug traffickers who had hired the men to help them smuggle cocaine said the boats had been bombed by the U.S. military, which had just released videos showing two missile strikes that it said killed eight "narco-terrorists" in the Pacific.

For months, Washington has

threatened to bomb cartel targets in Mexico, a scenario Mexican President Claudia Sheinbaum firmly rejects. "The Mexican people," she has said, will never accept "violations of Mexican territory, whether by land, sea or air."

Yet U.S. airstrikes have already struck Mexican vessels carrying Mexican citizens in international waters off the country's coast, according to a Times investigation. That includes the fatal strikes on Feb. 16 on the eight men from Nayarit state.

At least five additional Mexicans have died in U.S. boat strikes in other parts of Latin America, according to Times re-

[See Mexico, A3]

Kaiser's dispute process draws calls for reform

HMO, patients spar over whether unusual arbitration system is fair. State may step in.

BY MELODY PETERSEN

Wilfredo Engalla, a 51-year-old Filipino immigrant, alleged in a medical malpractice case that Kaiser doctors misdiagnosed him with colds and allergies for

years before eventually informing him he had terminal lung cancer.

He died before his complaint could be heard by an arbitrator, which his Kaiser policy required. His case prompted a withering rebuke from the California Supreme Court, which said Kaiser's system of arbitrating legal disputes was subject to long delays and unfair to its members. The year was 1997.

Nearly three decades af-

ter the landmark decision, the HMO giant — which made a series of sweeping reforms after the ruling — is once again facing questions over whether its arbitration system is stacked against the interests of its members.

Plaintiffs attorneys, legislators and patients say Kaiser's private and confidential process for arbitrating legal disputes over medical care still has key flaws that favor Kaiser over patients bringing malpractice

cases. The company insures about 25% of Californians, including some employees of the Los Angeles Times.

"Kaiser has really lost its way," said Assemblyman Robert Garcia (D-Rancho Cucamonga). Garcia, who is a longtime Kaiser member, recently introduced a bill to require the California attorney general to oversee arbitrations mandated by any health plan.

Kaiser defended its arbitration system, saying in a

statement that it was fair for patients and the nonprofit.

Many companies and other organizations, including some hospitals, HMOs and physician groups, require their customers or patients to take their complaints to private arbitration rather than to court.

But unlike most other companies, which send claims to large arbitration firms, Kaiser created its own system back in 1971.

[See Kaiser, A8]



PATRICK SMITH FIFA/Getty Images

THE 2026 WORLD CUP'S closing ceremony at MetLife Stadium in New Jersey.

Despite some misfires, this World Cup was a big success

BY KEVIN BAXTER

EAST RUTHERFORD, N.J. — The largest, longest and most complex World Cup in history came to a close Sunday, with Spain beating Argentina 1-0 in extra time. But FIFA president Gianni Infantino didn't bother waiting for the final result before passing judgment on the tournament.

"By all means this World Cup has exceeded all expectations," he said during a reception at Trump Tower two

days before the final kicked off. "This has not just been the greatest FIFA World Cup of all time. It is the greatest human social and cultural event that mankind has ever witnessed."

No, but it was pretty good, with FIFA emerging as the World Cup's biggest winner, allowing Infantino to reportedly shore up support within the organization despite a number of norm-shattering decisions during the tournament.

Attendance topped 6.8 million, a World Cup record

averaging more than 65,000 fans a game. FIFA estimated the cumulative global TV audience topped 5 billion people across linear television, digital streaming and social platforms while more than 1.8 billion people were expected to watch the final, according to the BusinessStats website, making it the most-viewed sporting event in history.

Exact figures won't be known for a few days.

Revenue for the four-year World Cup cycle is antici-

[See World Cup, A6]

WORLD CUP FINAL: Spain outlasts Argentina 1-0 in a thriller ending. SPORTS, D1

ANALYSIS

Trump may be stumbling into a 'forever war'

Long a critic of such entanglements, the president appears to be ensnared in Iran.

BY NABIH BULOS

BEIRUT — President Trump long railed against forever wars.

For years, whether as president or candidate, he flayed electoral opponents and previous presidents with his signature barbs, calling their entanglements a "complete waste of time" (Afghanistan), "the worst single mistake ever made in the history of our country" (Iraq) and "stupid" (Ukraine).

Yet he now appears to be stumbling into a forever war of his own.

From the first days of the U.S.-Israeli campaign against Iran, Trump and his officials insisted their adventure abroad would be the exception, that the conflict would end in a matter of weeks.

Now, 4½ months later, after a torturous, start-stop vacillation between truce and war, the U.S. is pressing on with a fight that has no end in sight — or even a clear definition of what an accept-

able end would be.

In the last week, the ceasefire collapsed, with the U.S. and Iran trading daily waves of strikes, leading to the deaths of two American servicemen on Friday when Iranian ballistic missiles struck Muwaffaq Salti Air Base in Jordan, where U.S. assets and personnel are stationed.

On Sunday, as the U.S. and Iran launched more air assaults, the U.S. announced that a service member was killed Saturday in Iraq during the controlled detonation of unexploded ordnance from a downed Iranian one-way attack drone.

The deaths in Jordan were the first combat fatalities since the U.S. and Iran agreed to a ceasefire. One soldier remains missing, according to a statement from U.S. Central Command.

Including the most recent casualties, 17 U.S. service members have been killed and more than 430 wounded since the war began, the Pentagon says.

In Iran, at least 57 people have been killed and more than 517 injured in U.S. attacks in the last three weeks, according to Iranian health authorities. The death toll since the beginning of the

[See Analysis, A4]

ANOTHER U.S. DEATH: Military announces a third weekend fatality; strikes on Iran continue. WORLD, A2

Facing drought and water restrictions, farmers turn to solar

BY BLANCA BEGERT AND IAN JAMES

California's Central Valley is one of the country's richest farming regions, blessed with fertile soils, sunny days and a massive man-made system of irrigation canals and reservoirs.

But as climate change intensifies, droughts deepen, and water restrictions kick in, growers in much of the valley are getting less water for their fields. They also face new limits on how much they can pump from underground, forcing them to leave hundreds of thousands of acres dry in the coming years. Some are turning to an answer they never thought they'd embrace: solar.

"We still want to farm, but taking the chance that water will be here was too risky," said Todd Tracy, a fifth-generation farmer, as he drove through his groves of green pistachio trees about a half-hour west of Bakersfield.

In 2021, he optioned about a third of his family's 8,600 acres to a solar developer, Avantus. The company is planning the largest solar-plus-storage project in the country, called Buttonbush. Its panels will eventually cover almost 12,000 acres and link up to a substation near the tiny town of Buttonwillow, before sending two gigawatts of electricity, enough to power 1 million homes, across the state.

"We weren't all for this, but we had to find a use for [See Solar, A6]

More pipes burst amid WeHo repairs

A section of Sunset Boulevard remained closed after last week's water main rupture. CALIFORNIA, B3

'Alien terrorist' court resurrected

Trump administration activates long-dormant body in its deportation crackdown. NATION, A5

An epic quest to revive film craft

"The Odyssey" shines a light on those keeping 70mm analog film alive. ENTERTAINMENT, E1

Weather
Partly sunny.
L.A. Basin: 88/68. B5

